FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

SEND Policy

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1.0 AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

Futures Matter - Northwood is an independent special school for up to 20 pupils aged 11 to 16. Every pupil has an education, health and care (EHC) plan, and our pupils have social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) needs and autism spectrum conditions (ASC), often with other complex needs. This policy sets out how we identify, assess, plan for and review the special educational needs and disabilities (SEND) of every pupil.

Our SEND policy aims to:

- make sure the school fully implements national legislation and guidance on pupils with SEND, and follows the SEND Code of Practice
- set out how we support and make provision for every pupil, so that each pupil can take part in all aspects of school life
- help every pupil to fulfil their aspirations, achieve their best and become a confident individual living a fulfilling life
- help every pupil make a successful transition into adulthood, with a clear next step at 16
- involve pupils and their parents or carers in discussions and decisions about support and provision
- explain the roles and responsibilities of everyone involved in providing for our pupils
- make sure all staff understand and apply this policy consistently

2.0 VISION AND VALUES

Our pupils have often had a difficult experience of school. Many have had previous placements break down, have missed a lot of education and have come to believe that school is not for them. Our vision is that every pupil feels safe, known and valued, and goes on to learn, achieve and move on to a positive next step.

At Futures Matter - Northwood we will:

- give every pupil access to a broad and balanced curriculum, with the support and adjustments they need to learn
- start from what each pupil can do and what matters to them, and plan around their strengths as well as their needs
- understand behaviour as communication, and respond with relationships, regulation and support before sanctions
- work in genuine partnership with parents, carers, placing local authorities and other professionals
- keep high expectations for every pupil, whatever their starting point
- make sure that no pupil's special educational needs become a reason for them to be excluded, or to be left without the support in their EHC plan

3.0 LEGISLATION AND GUIDANCE

This policy is based on the statutory guidance Special Educational Needs and Disability (SEND) Code of Practice: 0 to 25 years, Keeping Children Safe in Education (KCSIE) 2026 and Working Together to Improve School Attendance. It is also based on the following legislation:

- Part 3 of the Children and Families Act 2014, which sets out schools' responsibilities for pupils with SEND
- The Special Educational Needs and Disability Regulations 2014, which set out responsibilities for EHC plans, SEN co-ordinators and the SEN information report
- The Equality Act 2010 (section 20), which sets out the school's duty to make reasonable adjustments for pupils with disabilities
- The Public Sector Equality Duty (section 149 of the Equality Act 2010), which sets out the duty to eliminate discrimination, advance equality of opportunity and foster good relations
- The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, which set out the standards that an independent school must meet, including for the quality of education, welfare, and the provision for pupils with SEND

Section 41. The SEND Code of Practice applies directly to an independent school only if it is approved under section 41 of the Children and Families Act 2014. We are seeking that approval. Until we are listed, we follow the Code as good practice and make our provision in line with it, so that our policy and practice will meet its requirements from the day we are approved.

4.0 INCLUSION AND EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES

We strive to create an inclusive environment that offers every pupil, whatever their needs and abilities, a broad, balanced and challenging curriculum. We are committed to offering every pupil the chance to thrive and fulfil their aspirations.

We will achieve this by making reasonable adjustments to teaching, the curriculum and the school environment, so that every pupil is included in all aspects of school life. Our Accessibility Plan sets out how we increase the extent to which disabled pupils can take part in the curriculum, improve the physical environment, and improve the availability of accessible information.

We do not treat any pupil less favourably because of their SEND or disability. We never use a pupil's SEND as a reason to exclude them, to place them on a reduced timetable without proper agreement, or to remove them from the roll (see our Suspension and Exclusion Policy).

5.0 DEFINITIONS

5.1 Special Educational Needs

A pupil has special educational needs (SEN) if they have a learning difficulty or disability that requires special educational provision to be made for them. They have a learning difficulty or disability if they have:

- a significantly greater difficulty in learning than most others of the same age, or
- a disability which prevents or hinders them from making use of the facilities of a kind generally provided for others of the same age in mainstream schools

Special educational provision is educational or training provision that is additional to, or different from, that made generally for other children or young people of the same age in mainstream schools.

5.2 Disability

A pupil has a disability if they have a physical or mental impairment that has a substantial and long-term adverse effect on their ability to do normal daily activities. We make reasonable adjustments so that pupils with disabilities are not at a substantial disadvantage compared with their peers.

5.3 The Four Areas of Need

The needs of pupils with SEND are grouped into four broad areas. Pupils can have needs that cut across more than one area, and their needs may change over time. We choose support that is right for each pupil's area or areas of need at the time.

Area of need	What this means
Communication and interaction	Pupils have difficulty communicating with others. They may find it hard to understand what is said to them, to express themselves, or to understand and use the social rules of communication. Pupils on the autism spectrum often have needs in this area.
Cognition and learning	Pupils learn at a slower pace than their peers, or have a specific learning difficulty such as dyslexia, dyscalculia or dyspraxia, or a moderate, severe or profound and multiple learning difficulty.
Social, emotional and mental health	Pupils may have mental health difficulties such as anxiety or depression, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, attachment difficulties, or have experienced adverse childhood experiences or trauma. These needs can show as challenging, disruptive or distressing behaviour, or as a pupil becoming withdrawn or isolated.
Sensory and/or physical	Pupils have a disability that hinders them from using the educational facilities generally provided, such as a sensory impairment (vision, hearing or multi-sensory) or a physical impairment. They may need ongoing support and equipment.

5.4 Our Pupils

The primary need of our pupils is SEMH, and most also have needs in communication and interaction, including autism. Many also have needs in cognition and learning, sensory processing, speech, language and communication, and some have additional medical needs. Every pupil's needs are set out in their EHC plan, and our provision is built around that plan.

6.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

The school does not currently have a special educational needs co-ordinator (SENCo). Until one is appointed, the Head Teacher carries out the SENCo's duties set out below, supported by the staff team.

Who	Responsibilities
The Head Teacher (SEND co-ordination)	Has overall responsibility for the provision for pupils with SEND and their progress, and for the day-to-day operation of this policy. Informs parents or carers of their child's needs and provision, and liaises with them. Makes sure every pupil's EHC plan is understood by staff, and that the provision in it is delivered and recorded. Co-ordinates the provision for each pupil, including the Individual Support Plan and the Positive Behaviour Support Plan. Is the main contact for the placing local authority and other agencies. Organises annual reviews and early reviews, and tells the local authority when a pupil needs a re-assessment or an early review of their plan. Advises staff on the graduated approach and on teaching methods that suit each pupil. Monitors the school's SEND budget and resources. Plans transition into and out of the school. Keeps records of all pupils with SEND accurate and up to date. Works with the Board to make sure the school meets its duties under the Equality Act 2010. With the Board, identifies staff training needs and plans professional development. Prepares the SEN information report and reviews this policy.
Teachers	Plan and provide high-quality teaching, adapted to every pupil's needs, using the graduated approach. Are responsible for the progress and development of every pupil they teach, including where pupils are supported by teaching assistants or other staff. Work with teaching assistants and specialist staff to plan and review support, and link it to teaching in class. Follow this policy, each pupil's EHC plan and Individual Support Plan, and the SEN information report. Talk with parents or carers regularly about outcomes, support and progress.
Teaching assistants and support staff	Deliver the support set out in pupils' plans, and give feedback to teachers on how pupils respond. Know each pupil's needs, triggers and what helps them, and use the agreed approaches consistently.
The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Makes sure that safeguarding and the additional vulnerabilities of pupils with SEND are considered in all planning (section 11). The Head Teacher is the DSL, and the Deputy DSLs are Carrie-Ann McGurk (Proprietor) and Simone Welch.
The Proprietor and the School Governance Board	Make sure the duties in this policy are carried out. Do all they can to make sure every pupil with SEND gets the support they need. Make sure pupils with SEND take part in the activities of the school alongside others. Make sure the school has a clear approach to identifying and responding to SEND, and records accurately the provision made. Make sure parents and carers are told when special educational provision is made, and given an annual report on progress. Publish the SEN information report and Accessibility Plan. Make sure arrangements are in place for pupils with medical conditions. Determine how resources are used to support pupils with SEND. Make sure the person responsible for SEND co-ordination is suitably qualified and trained, and has enough time for the role. Make sure all pupils receive independent careers guidance.

Who	Responsibilities
The SEND link member of the Board	The Chair of the School Governance Board acts as the SEND link, unless the Board appoints another member. Raises awareness of SEND at Board meetings, monitors the quality and effectiveness of provision and reports to the Board, and works with the Head Teacher on the development of this policy and of provision.
Parents or carers	Tell the school about any concerns about their child's progress or development, share what they know about their child's needs and what works, and take part in reviews. They are always given the chance to give information and their views, and to take part in discussions and decisions (section 8.5).
The pupil	Is always given the chance to say what their strengths and difficulties are, to help set their targets and outcomes, to attend and speak at review meetings, and to give feedback on what works. Their views are taken into account in decisions that affect them (section 8.5).
The placing local authority	Keeps the EHC plan, funds the placement, carries out assessments and annual reviews and decides whether to amend or cease the plan. We work with the local authority on every pupil's plan.

7.0 SEN INFORMATION REPORT AND LOCAL OFFER

We publish a SEN information report on our website, which sets out how this policy is put into practice in the school. It is written for parents, carers and pupils, and is updated every year and as soon as possible after any change to the information it contains.

We work with the local authorities that place pupils with us, including Birmingham City Council, and give them information about our provision for inclusion in their local offers.

8.0 OUR APPROACH TO SEND SUPPORT

8.1 Before a Pupil Starts

Every pupil joins us with an EHC plan that names the school. Before a place is agreed, we follow our Admissions Policy: we read the EHC plan and assessments, consult with the local authority, meet the pupil and their parents or carers, and decide whether we can meet the pupil's needs and make the provision in the plan, and whether they can be educated safely alongside the other pupils.

Once a place is agreed, we work with the previous school, the local authority and other professionals to get the information we need before the pupil starts, so that support is in place from the first day. We make sure all staff who will work with the pupil know their needs before they arrive.

8.2 Induction and the Fresh Start Conversation

We understand that every pupil and family has a story, and that many have had poor experiences of school. Before the pupil starts, we hold a Fresh Start conversation with the pupil and their parents or carers (Appendix 1). We listen to what has worked and what has

not, what matters to the pupil, their strengths and interests, and what worries them. Where a pupil already has a professional network, we invite those professionals to a meeting.

A pupil's induction is paced to the pupil. It may be a few days or several weeks, and it includes time for the pupil to get to know staff, the building and the routines before they join a full timetable. During induction we:

- complete baseline assessments of the pupil's reading, writing, mathematics, communication and other skills, building on information from previous settings
- identify triggers, sensory needs, interests and what helps the pupil to regulate, and write these into their Positive Behaviour Support Plan
- agree an Individual Support Plan with the pupil and their parents or carers, based on the outcomes in the EHC plan
- give all staff a summary of the pupil's needs and the agreed approach

8.3 Assessing and Identifying Needs

The EHC plan sets out each pupil's needs, but needs change and new needs can emerge. We keep assessing throughout the pupil's time with us. We look at the pupil's progress against their EHC plan outcomes and against their baseline, across all areas of learning and development, including communication, social understanding, emotional regulation and independence.

When a pupil's progress is slower than expected, or staff notice a change in their needs, the class teacher raises it with the Head Teacher. We consider short-term causes, such as bullying, bereavement or changes at home, and take particular care for pupils whose first language is not English. Where needed, and with parents' or carers' agreement, we consult an external specialist. If we think a pupil's needs have changed or are not being met by the plan, we ask the placing local authority for an early review of the EHC plan, or for a re-assessment.

8.4 The Graduated Approach

We use the graduated approach, a four-part cycle of assess, plan, do and review, for every pupil. We repeat the cycle, each time with a better understanding of what helps the pupil to make progress.

Stage	What we do
Assess	The class teacher and the Head Teacher analyse the pupil's needs, using the EHC plan, our own assessments, observations, and the views of the pupil and their parents or carers. We seek advice from external specialists where needed. We review assessments regularly, because watching how a pupil responds to support is often the best way to understand their needs.
Plan	With the pupil and their parents or carers, we decide which adjustments, interventions and support to put in place, the outcomes we expect and a date for review. This goes into the pupil's Individual Support Plan and Positive Behaviour Support Plan, recorded on our systems and shared with every member of staff who works with the pupil. Parents and carers know what is planned and may be asked to support it at home.

Stage	What we do
Do	The class or subject teacher stays responsible for the pupil's progress, even where the plan involves 1-to-1 or small group work with other staff. Staff deliver the plan, use the agreed approaches consistently, and record what they see.
Review	We review the plan at least every term, and sooner if needed. We look at the pupil's progress towards their outcomes, the views of the pupil, parents or carers and staff, and the impact of each intervention. We then change the outcomes and support, in consultation with the pupil and their parents or carers.

8.5 Working with Pupils and Parents or Carers

We put the pupil and their parents or carers at the heart of decisions about special educational provision, and take their views into account in every decision. We will:

- talk with parents or carers regularly, and keep a record of what was discussed and agreed, which we share with them
- invite parents or carers to meet us each term to review their child's provision and progress
- ask parents or carers about the impact of support outside school and any changes in their child's needs
- give parents or carers a written report on their child's progress at least once a year, alongside the annual review of the EHC plan
- talk with the pupil about their strengths, difficulties and targets, invite them to their review meetings, ask for their feedback on what works, and use pupil voice and pupil-friendly formats so that the pupil can take part
- tell parents or carers when we make special educational provision for their child, and when we are concerned about their child's needs

8.6 EHC Plans and Annual Reviews

The EHC plan is a legal document that sets out the pupil's needs, the provision that will be made and the outcomes sought. The placing local authority is responsible for the plan. We:

- hold an annual review of each pupil's EHC plan, with the pupil, their parents or carers, the local authority and the professionals involved, giving everyone the notice and reports they need, and sending the report of the meeting to the local authority within the required time
- from Year 9 onwards, focus annual reviews on preparing for adulthood, including the pupil's aspirations, independence, health, community life and next steps
- hold early reviews when a pupil's needs or circumstances change significantly, or when we think the provision is not meeting their needs
- work with the local authority at the phase transfer review for pupils in Year 11, so that the next placement is agreed and named in good time
- record the provision made, and the progress made towards each outcome in the plan

8.7 Therapeutic and Specialist Support

We recognise that the school cannot meet every need alone. Alongside the curriculum, we provide support to help pupils to regulate, communicate and feel safe, and we use a calm, low-arousal environment and consistent routines. Where a pupil's plan includes therapeutic or specialist provision, such as speech and language therapy, occupational therapy or counselling, we make sure it is arranged, delivered and recorded, and that staff know how to carry over the advice into daily practice. Where the provision in a plan is not being delivered, we tell the local authority.

8.8 Preparing for Adulthood and Transition

From the start we plan with every pupil for their life after school. Our pupils receive independent careers guidance, and we plan work experience and other opportunities that match their aspirations. We help pupils to build independence, communication, and the skills they need for employment, training or further education. In Year 11 we work with the pupil, their family, the local authority and post-16 providers on transition, including visits, taster days and a handover of information, so that the pupil has a place and a plan before they leave. We also plan carefully for any pupil who moves to another school during their time with us, and send all relevant information on time.

8.9 Examinations and Access Arrangements

We assess pupils' need for access arrangements in public examinations early, using evidence of how they normally work. Arrangements can include extra time, rest breaks, a prompter, a reader, a scribe, a separate room or specialist equipment, as allowed by the awarding bodies. We make reasonable adjustments so that SEND is not a barrier to a pupil showing what they can do.

8.10 Evaluating the Effectiveness of SEND Provision

We evaluate the effectiveness of our provision for pupils with SEND by:

- tracking each pupil's progress towards the outcomes in their EHC plan and Individual Support Plan
- carrying out the review stage of the graduated approach every term
- holding annual reviews of every EHC plan
- collecting the views of pupils and their parents or carers, including through questionnaires
- monitoring the quality of teaching and of interventions
- reporting to the Proprietor and the Board each term

9.0 BEHAVIOUR AND SEND

We understand that behaviour is a way of communicating. For our pupils, behaviour that challenges is often linked to their SEND, to trauma or to sensory needs. We use the GCM approach set out in our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, together with a Positive Behaviour Support Plan for every pupil, so that staff understand and respond to each pupil's needs consistently.

Our Restrictive Interventions Policy sets out our approach to the use of force, which we use only as a last resort, and always in line with the pupil's plan. Before we consider a suspension or permanent exclusion, we consider the pupil's SEND and EHC plan, we

consider whether the provision is meeting the pupil's needs, and we ask the local authority for an early review of the plan where it is not. Our Suspension and Exclusion Policy explains how we support a pupil to return through a reintegration meeting and plan.

10.0 ATTENDANCE

Many pupils with SEND face complex barriers to attendance. Their right to an education is the same as that of any other pupil, and our attendance ambition for them is the same, but they may need extra support. We work with each pupil and family to understand the barriers, such as anxiety or sensory needs, and plan support through the pupil's Individual Support Plan. We do not use a reduced timetable as a long-term response. Our approach to supporting pupils who are absent because of their SEND is set out in our Attendance Policy.

11.0 SAFEGUARDING

We recognise that pupils with SEND can face additional safeguarding challenges. Children with disabilities are more likely to be abused than their peers, and there can be additional barriers to recognising abuse, exploitation and neglect in this group. These include assuming that behaviour, mood or injuries relate to a pupil's condition without looking further, the pupil being more vulnerable to bullying without showing it, and communication difficulties in saying what has happened.

Staff are trained to look beyond the condition, to take the pupil's communication needs into account, and to report every concern to the Designated Safeguarding Lead. For more on the pastoral support we give and how we help pupils to overcome communication barriers, see section 10 of our Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy.

12.0 EXPERTISE AND TRAINING OF STAFF

All staff are trained in the needs of our pupils, including SEMH, autism, trauma, sensory processing and communication needs, and in the use of GCM. Training is provided at induction and regularly through the year, and the Head Teacher identifies staff training needs and builds them into our plan for professional development. Teachers are supported to adapt their teaching for every pupil in their class, through coaching, planning support, and advice from specialists. Staff who support pupils with specific needs, such as medical conditions, receive the training they need for that role. We keep a record of the training each member of staff has completed.

13.0 LINKS WITH EXTERNAL AGENCIES

The school recognises that it cannot meet all the needs of every pupil by itself. Where needed, we work with:

- the placing local authority, including SEND case officers and the Virtual School Head for looked-after children
- educational psychologists and specialist teachers
- speech and language therapists
- occupational therapists and physiotherapists
- child and adolescent mental health services (CAMHS), clinical psychologists and counselling services
- general practitioners, paediatricians and school nurses

- social workers and early help services
- careers advisers, colleges and other post-16 providers
- independent advice services for parents and young people, such as Birmingham SENDIASS

14.0 ADMISSION AND ACCESSIBILITY ARRANGEMENTS

14.1 Admission Arrangements

We admit pupils aged 11 to 16 who have an EHC plan that names the school or who are being considered for placement by a local authority, as set out in our Admissions Policy. Pupils who do not have an EHC plan are not admitted. We do not treat disabled pupils or pupils with SEN less favourably in our admission decisions, and we explain our reasons for any decision not to offer a place.

14.2 Accessibility Arrangements

Our Accessibility Plan sets out how we prevent disabled pupils from being treated less favourably, how we improve the physical environment, the facilities and auxiliary aids and services we provide, and how we improve the availability of accessible information. It is published on our website and reviewed regularly.

15.0 COMPLAINTS ABOUT SEND PROVISION

If parents or carers have a concern about our SEND provision, we encourage them to raise it informally first with their child's class teacher or the Head Teacher, and we will try to resolve it quickly. If that does not resolve it, they can make a formal complaint under our Complaints Policy. In some circumstances the pupil can also complain.

Some concerns are about decisions made by the local authority, such as the content of an EHC plan, the school named in it, or whether to carry out an assessment. These are not for the school to decide, and we will help families to find the right route. Parents and young people can ask for disagreement resolution or mediation, and can appeal to the First-tier Tribunal (SEND) about certain decisions. Claims of disability discrimination can be made to the First-tier Tribunal (SEND). See also chapter 11 of the SEND Code of Practice.

Free, independent and confidential information, advice and support is available from the SEN and disability information, advice and support service (SENDIASS) in the pupil's home local authority area. For pupils placed by Birmingham City Council, contact Birmingham SENDIASS by email at SENDIASS@Birmingham.gov.uk, by telephone on 0121 303 5004, or by post at Birmingham SENDIASS, PO Box 16270, Birmingham B2 2HN.

16.0 MONITORING AND EVALUATION

We are always looking for ways to improve this policy. Each year we evaluate whether we are meeting the aims in section 1 by looking at:

- whether all staff know the needs of the pupils they work with, at the start of each term
- how quickly a new pupil's needs are assessed and support is put in place
- the progress and outcomes of pupils against their EHC plan outcomes
- whether the provision in every EHC plan is delivered
- whether pupils feel safe, valued and included in the school community

- comments and feedback from pupils, parents and carers, and the local authorities that place pupils with us
- rates of attendance, suspension and exclusion, and use of restrictive interventions for pupils with different needs

This policy is reviewed every year by the Head Teacher, and is approved by the Proprietor and the School Governance Board. It is also reviewed when new legislation, guidance or changes to our procedures require it.

17.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES AND DOCUMENTS

- SEN information report
- Accessibility Plan
- Admissions Policy
- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy
- Restrictive Interventions Policy
- Suspension and Exclusion Policy
- Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy
- Attendance Policy
- Supporting Pupils with Medical Conditions Policy
- Complaints Policy
- Equality information and objectives

References: Special Educational Needs and Disability (SEND) Code of Practice: 0 to 25 years, DfE and DHSC; Model policy: SEND for schools, The Key (August 2025); SEND policy checklist, The Key; The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014; Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026.

18.0 APPENDICES

Appendix 1: Fresh Start Conversation Record

Appendix 2: Individual Support Plan Review

APPENDIX 1: FRESH START CONVERSATION RECORD

Complete this form with the pupil and their parents or carers before or at the start of the pupil's induction. Keep it on the pupil's file and give a copy to the parents or carers.

FRESH START CONVERSATION RECORD - to be completed with the pupil and family	
Pupil's name, date of birth, placing local authority and date of the conversation:	
Who took part (pupil, parents or carers, school staff, previous school, social worker, other professionals):	
What has gone well in the pupil's education so far:	
What has not gone well, and what the pupil and family would like us to do differently:	
The pupil's strengths, interests and what matters to them:	
What worries the pupil or the family about starting at the school:	
Triggers, sensory needs, communication needs and what helps the pupil to feel calm and safe:	
Health, medical and medication needs:	
Other professionals involved, and any network meeting needed:	
The pupil's hopes for the future and aspirations:	
Plan for induction (pace, key adult, first days, timetable):	
Signed (Head Teacher) and dated:	

APPENDIX 2: INDIVIDUAL SUPPORT PLAN REVIEW

Complete this form at the end of each term for every pupil, as the review stage of the graduated approach. Share it with the parents or carers and the pupil, and keep it on the pupil's file.

INDIVIDUAL SUPPORT PLAN REVIEW - to be completed each term	
Pupil's name, year group and date of review:	
EHC plan outcomes being worked towards:	
Progress made towards each outcome, with evidence:	
Support and interventions provided, and their impact:	
Provision in the EHC plan delivered in full? If not, what is missing and the action taken:	
The pupil's views:	
The views of the parents or carers:	
The views of the staff who work with the pupil:	
Changes to needs, the Positive Behaviour Support Plan or risk assessments:	
Outcomes and support agreed for next term, and the date of the next review:	
Does the local authority need to be asked for an early review of the EHC plan? Reason and date requested:	
Signed (Head Teacher) and dated:	